

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Judges

Judges

The book of Judges tells the stories of leaders whom God sent to rescue Israel from its enemies again and again. During this time, the people were often unfaithful to God's covenant (his binding agreement with them). So God allowed their enemies to rule over them. Israel often cried out to the Lord for help, and the Lord sent judges to rescue them.

These leaders did powerful things. But they could not end Israel's disorder and sin. Israel needed one leader with authority over the whole nation. This kind of leader could help bring the people together as a nation and give them unity.

Setting

The time of the judges is best understood in its own historical setting. Scholars have compared the book of Judges with other ancient stories about heroes. These include the stories of Homer, old Icelandic stories, and the French story *La Chanson de Roland*. Each of these comes the Heroic Age, a time when a people group was still forming its identity. In these stories, unusual men and women did not always follow normal customs. Their actions often went against accepted behavior. Yet they also did great things.

After Moses died, Joshua led the Israelites in battles to take the land. This gave the people a place to live. But it did not yet give them a stable society. That would take hundreds of years. It would not happen fully until Israel had a strong kingdom under King David.

Even so, Moses and Joshua did leave Israel with some order. The Bible says the tribes were already organized. The land had also been divided among them. A few main places of worship had become important, such as Gilgal and Shiloh. Priests, Levites, and tribal elders also helped bring order to the people.

The Israelites continued to remember their old traditions:

- They remembered God's covenant promise to Abraham, his binding promise to him and his family.
- They remembered their time living in Egypt.
- They remembered how God rescued them by his power.
- They also remembered their years in the wilderness and the time when God confirmed his covenant with them.

But something was still missing.

According to Judges, Israel had two main problems:

1. The opening sections of the book (1:1–2:5 and 2:6–3:6) explain that the tribes did not take full control of the land God had given them. They began to live like the people of Canaan instead of obeying God's covenant, the binding agreement God gave through Moses.
2. The closing sections of the book (chapters 17–21) show that Israel's society was not working well. This idea appears several times: Israel had no king, and the people did what seemed right to them (17:6; 18:1; 19:1; 21:25).

The opening sections focus on Israel's unfaithfulness to God. The closing sections focus on Israel's weak social order. The time of the heroes did not create the stable leadership Israel needed. Israel needed leaders and structures that could help the people of Israel live under God's rule.

The book of Judges does not, however, reject the kind of leadership that the judges had. God chose these leaders and gave them power by his Spirit. Through them, God led Israel and rescued the people from their enemies (see 2:16–19). The stories honor this kind of brave leadership. They show that the main weakness of this time was not the leaders whom God sent. The deeper problem was the people's sin. Judges suggests that Israel needed a different kind of leadership to deal with this problem.

Summary

The book of Judges has an A-B-A structure. This means the book begins and ends with similar kinds of sections, with the main stories in the middle. It begins with two opening sections. Each section starts after Joshua's death. This was an important event in Israel's life as a nation. It also connects the story of Judges with Joshua Joshua 24:28–31.

The first opening section (Judges 1:1–2:5) describes how individual tribes failed to obey God's covenant. They took only part of the land instead of fully possessing it. This showed that they did not honor the Lord's promise. As a result, the Lord said he would no longer drive out their enemies for them (Judges 2:1–3).

The second opening section (2:6–3:6) moves from the failures of the tribes to the leaders God used during a time of disorder. These leaders helped Israel continue to take and settle the land.

The story moves from Joshua to the elders who lived longer than he did. These elders had seen God's power

in the wilderness and in the conquest of the land. Then the story moves to the next generation. They “did not know the LORD or the works that He had done for Israel” (2:10).

This section then introduces the main feature of the book: the judges. God raised up these leaders to rescue Israel and call the people back to covenant obedience (2:16). This means obeying the binding agreement God had made with them. One sign of this obedience would be Israel’s faithful possession of the promised land.

Like the end of the first opening section, Judges 3:1–6 shows that Israel will fail.

The middle section (3:7–16:31) contains a series of cycles. In Judges, Israel sins, suffers under enemies, cries out to God, and receives a judge who rescues them. This section gives longer accounts of the six major judges: Othniel, Ehud, Deborah, Gideon, Jephthah, and Samson. It also gives shorter accounts of the six minor judges: Shamgar, Tola, Jair, Ibzan, Elon, and Abdon.

This section also includes Abimelech (chapter 9). He was not like the judges whom God raised up to rescue Israel. His rule was more like the rule of a king.

After Abimelech, Israel’s condition becomes worse. The earlier judges, from Othniel to Gideon, are shown in a more positive way. The later judges, especially Jephthah and Samson, are more morally difficult.

In all, there were 12 judges. This number may connect them with the 12 tribes of Israel (see study note on 12:8). As the book continues, Israel moves toward greater disorder. This shows that the people needed a more unified society with stronger central leadership.

The book of Judges ends with two closing sections (chapters 17–18 and 19–21). These sections show that Israel failed as a nation and failed to live faithfully before God. They also show the spiritual and social disorder that followed. The closing sections repeat this idea: “In those days there was no king in Israel” (see 17:6; 18:1; 19:1; 21:25). Two of these verses also say that the people did what seemed right to them (17:6; 21:25). This ending points toward the need for a new kind of leadership. Israel needed leadership that could reverse the nation’s decline and bring greater order.

Authors and Date of Composition

We do not know who wrote or gathered the material in Judges. The historical books, from Joshua to 2 Kings, tell one connected story. Tradition says that different sources were brought together into a theological story, a story that explains God’s work and Israel’s response. This may have happened under the influence

of Israel’s prophetic schools, groups connected with prophets and their teaching.

Evidence from the end of this history may point to the exile in Babylon as the latest possible time when this material was written or gathered together (2 Kings 25:27–30). The book of Judges may have received its final form at the same time.

However, little in Judges itself points to a time later than the early monarchy, when Israel first began to be ruled by kings. The book does not mention a central place of worship or a national capital in Jerusalem. The society shown in Judges is still trying to settle the land and form a stable government.

Timeline of Events in Judges

For many years, scholars have asked how the accounts of the judges fit into the timeline from Joshua to Saul. It is very difficult to date the judges or put them in order. The answer depends partly on when the exodus took place. The exodus was the time when God rescued Israel from Egypt. Some scholars date the exodus to the 1400s BC. Others date it to the 1200s BC.

The longer timeline is based on the earlier date for the exodus. This timeline fits well with Judges 11:26 and 1 Kings 6:1. The shorter timeline is based on the later date for the exodus. This timeline seems to fit better with evidence outside the Bible, such as archaeological findings. But it places the time of the judges into a much shorter period.

The people of Israel entered the land of Canaan in either 1406 or 1230 BC. The date depends on when the exodus happened (see Exodus Book Introduction, “The Date of the Exodus”). After this, the people of Israel lived in the land. Again and again, nearby nations oppressed them. God rescued them through different judges. This continued until the prophet Samuel anointed Saul as king over all Israel around 1050 BC.

The accounts of the judges are told in order. This can make it seem as if each judge served after the previous judge. Most of these accounts also tell how much time passed. They tell how long enemies ruled over God’s people and how long the land had peace after each judge rescued Israel. They also tell how long the land had peace after each judge rescued Israel. However, if these numbers are simply added together, the total is too long. It is longer than the time available for this period in Israel’s history.

One way to solve this problem is to understand that the judges did not always serve one after another. Sometimes they served as judges at the same time. For example, Judges 10:7 says, “So the anger of the

LORD burned against Israel, and He sold them into the hands of the Philistines and Ammonites.” This suggests that Jephthah rescued his people from the Ammonites in the northeast. At the same time, Samson began to rescue Israel from the Philistines in the southwest.

In some cases, the book of Judges does show that one judge came after another. For example, Shamgar judged “after Ehud” (3:31). Deborah judged, “After Ehud died” (4:1; see also 5:6). Even so, Judges does not give this kind of connection for most of the judges. Also, most judges had influence over only one part of Israel’s land. The time of the judges was marked by moral evil, spiritual darkness, and political division. None of the judges led the whole nation. Each judge was followed by only a few tribes at most. These were usually the tribes near the judge’s hometown.

When we understand that the judges were local leaders and that their times of leadership often overlapped, the timeline becomes easier to explain. We can see how the period of the judges fits within Israel’s history.

Meaning and Message

What kind of leadership does God’s work require? Where can God’s people find such leaders? The book of Judges gives part of the answer to both questions. But it does not give the final answer.

The book of Judges celebrates charismatic leadership. This means leadership that is gifted and inspired by God. But Judges also shows the limits of this kind of leadership. One lasting biblical principle is that God raises up leaders and fills them with his Spirit to rescue his people. Moses and Joshua were leaders like this. Saul and David would also become leaders like this. The heroes in Judges had serious weaknesses. Even so, God still used them. A true charismatic leader is a man or woman who receives a gift from God. This gift gives the person what is needed for the work.

A second kind of leadership is often called official leadership. This kind of leadership comes from a role or appointment. This kind of authority does not always come directly from a special gift from God. Instead, it comes from a role or appointment. The judges of Israel were clear examples of charismatic leaders, leaders gifted and inspired by God. The kings were different. They had official authority in the military and government. Israel’s prophets and priests often showed a similar difference in spiritual life. In general, prophets were inspired leaders. Priests were official leaders.

Which kind of leader has God’s approval? How can people who want to follow the Lord know which leaders and forms of leadership they should obey? The book of Judges shows that God is fully committed to raising up leaders for the right time. He gives them power and fills them with his Spirit. Even with its limits, charismatic leadership, leadership gifted and inspired by God, continues throughout the Bible.

Even when Israel began to have kings in 1 and 2 Samuel, the Bible shows mixed feelings about this new kind of official leadership. Kingship began with Saul. He was like both a judge and a king. He had power from God’s Spirit, but he also held an official role as king. Yet the weaknesses of both kinds of leadership came together in him and led to his fall. Then God affirmed and renewed charismatic leadership in David, a great hero-king. David was so clearly gifted and inspired by God that, at first, he looks much like a successful judge.

Judges shows the need for better leadership. The answer is not to reject charismatic leaders, leaders gifted and inspired by God. The answer is the addition of God’s covenant with David, his chosen king (2 Samuel 7:1-29). God’s ideal brings together inspired leadership and official leadership. Israel’s judges and kings had many limits. But they point forward to Jesus, the perfect Spirit-filled King. In himself, Jesus brings together the good qualities that earlier leaders lacked.